Going Up to Hamburg

Solo Harp / Old Time • Key of E • A Diatonic Harmonica • 2nd Position • AABB Fox Chase Form

Source: Learned from Mark Graham • Origin: Northern Mississippi (John Hatcher, 1939)

Watch the Lesson

Notation: S = Scoop " = whole tone bend G = Ghost octave ... = sustained note / = split (e.g. +3/6 = holes 3 and 6)

A Part — Play Twice

Basic Melody

```
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
-"3 -3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -2 -1
```

Variation 1 — Scoops

```
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -"3 -2 -S3 -S3
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -2 -1
```

Variation 2 — Ascending Run

```
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -"3 -2 -3 -4
+3 -"3 -2 +2 -2
+3 -2 -1
```

B Part — Play Twice

Low/Mid Octave — Basic Melody

```
-2 +34 +34 -3 -4 +5 +6 +5 +6
+5 -4 -3      +5 -4 -3 -2
-2 +34 +34 -3 -4 +5 +6 +5 +6
-6 -7 -6 +6 +5 -4 -3 -2
+5... -3...
```

High Octave Variation

```
+6 +6 +6 -7 -8 +8 +9 +8 +9
+8 -8 -7    +8 -8 -7 +6   (x2)
+8... -7...
```

Alternate B Part — Ghost Octave Splits

```
+3/6 +3/6 +3/6 -3/7 -4/8 +5/8 +6/9 +5/8 +6/9
-6/10 -7/11(G) -6/10 +6/9 +5/8 -4/8 -3/7 +3/6
```

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Next step: add ghost octave variations to the high octave B part.

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Origins

"Going Up to Hamburg" is a tune from northern Mississippi, reported to have evolved from a holler into a fiddle tune. The title refers to Hamburg, a community in Hardin County, Tennessee, just across the state line from Tishomingo County, Mississippi. As musicologist Tom Rankin has noted, the melody almost follows the vocal line in unison — a hallmark of tunes that grew out of the field holler tradition.

The earliest known recording was made in 1939 by Herbert Halpert and Abbott Ferriss as part of a joint project between the WPA and the Library of Congress. The fiddler was John Hatcher (1886–1958) of Tishomingo County, Mississippi. Hatcher learned to play from his grandfather Thomas Nixon, a Civil War veteran, and from neighbours Dick Brown and George Cheek, who played dances in the local area. Hatcher continued that tradition himself, playing for neighbourhood dances and on the radio with The Tishomingo County Jamboree Boys.

The tune is typically played as either AABB or ABB. You can hear an ABB version by the Rhythm Rats — try playing along with it and you'll notice there are variations in the intervals between the A and B parts, so you need big ears to settle into these tunes. That's great practice in itself.

Mark Graham & This Version

Mark Graham has been playing old time, Irish traditional, and country blues music on the diatonic harmonica for over fifty years. Based in Washington state, he has been a member of bands including The Hurricane Ridgerunners, The Chicken Chokers, Kevin Burke's Open House, and The Brainstormers, performing all over North America and Europe. His album with Tom Sauber, "Thought I Heard It Blow" (recorded 2000, released 2001), features their version of Going Up to Hamburg alongside other fiddle tunes and blues played on banjo and harmonica.

This version was learned directly from Mark Graham when he visited the UK around 2012–2014. It is played as a solo piece in the fox chase style — AABB form with a brief fox chase intro each time through. The A part melody sits around holes 1–3 with whole tone bends and scoops giving the vocal, holler-like quality. The B part opens up into the mid and high registers with two octave options, plus a ghost octave split variation for those who want to push it further.

Playing This Tune

This is played in second position on an A diatonic harmonica in the key of E. The AABB fox chase form gives the tune its structure — a brief rhythmic fox chase intro kicks off each repeat. The A part offers three variations: the basic melody, a version with scoops on the 3 draw, and one with an ascending run into holes 3 and 4. The B part starts in the low/mid register, then you can take it up to the high octave, and finally add ghost octave splits for the full effect. Build it up one layer at a time — get the basic melody solid, then add the variations and the fox chase rhythm underneath.

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